THE INNER HORIZON



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Volume IV: Echoes at the Edge



A poetry anthology
The Inner Horizon

ÍÑIGO BARRERA BARCELÓ

Echoes at the Edge. Lyric of the Emotional Threshold
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The twenty-one poems and the glossary come from the poetry section of The Inner Horizon and are reproduced here in the order the work presents them.
The illustrations belong to the same work. They are listed one by one at the end of the volume.
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To whoever stayed on the shore
when the water withdrew.

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THE WORK IN FOUR VOLUMES

The Inner Horizon is one work told four times.

Its premise is a game with a single rule. Suppose that consciousness has the structure of an event horizon, the boundary of a Hawking micro black hole, and follow the supposition wherever it leads. It is a thought experiment, and the work never claims more for it. Where the idea lights something up, the work says so. Where it breaks, the work says that too.

A question like this will not keep to one register. It changes as it passes from physics to grief, from grief to a film, from a film to a kitchen at dawn. So the work was written in four voices, and each voice became a volume.

Volume I, Essay. The argument itself: the hypothesis, built chapter by chapter, and the point where it stops.

Volume II, Topological Readings. The hypothesis put to work on things that were made without it: novels, films, paintings, a football match.

Volume III, Fables from Tarel. The same idea told as short narratives, in and around a city that learned to live with the water that leaves.

Volume IV, Echoes at the Edge. The same idea in the language of feeling, as poems.

The volumes are independent. Each can be read alone and in any order, and none asks you to finish another first. Together they say one thing four times, and what changes from one telling to the next is where the weight falls.

This volume. This is the fourth volume, and the shortest. The essay argues, the readings test and the tales narrate; the poems

inhabit. They do not defend the hypothesis. They ask what it feels like to stand inside a boundary, what hurts when it cracks, and what remains when the water on the other side recedes. Twenty-one poems and an intimate glossary, in three books, close the work.

Each poem opens on an odd-numbered page, facing its illustration. The plates are listed one by one at the end of the volume.

You do not need to have read the other volumes to read this one. At most, you need to have once stood on a shore watching the water leave, not knowing if it would return, and not knowing what it might bring back.



BOOK ONE

The Architecture with a Hollow

Nine ways into a mourning: what remains when the water recedes and you have to keep measuring the shore.



I

The Bubble

The soap stretches in my hands,
it curves.
Suddenly, I form a sphere:
an inside and an outside
that did not exist before.

It is a living boundary,
I feel it on my own skin.

I am the void that, as it collapses,
creates something like a star.

The water recedes.
I do not tear away,
I say goodbye.



II

The Archivist

The water left the way
polite guests leave:
by night,
leaving the room ready
for someone I do not know.

I recorded the first strip of mud
in the handwriting of normal days.
There are hands that do not know
they are writing a farewell.

The children show their blisters
like coins from a country
that does not yet exist.

I leave holes in the notebook.
And at night, asleep,
I still row.



III

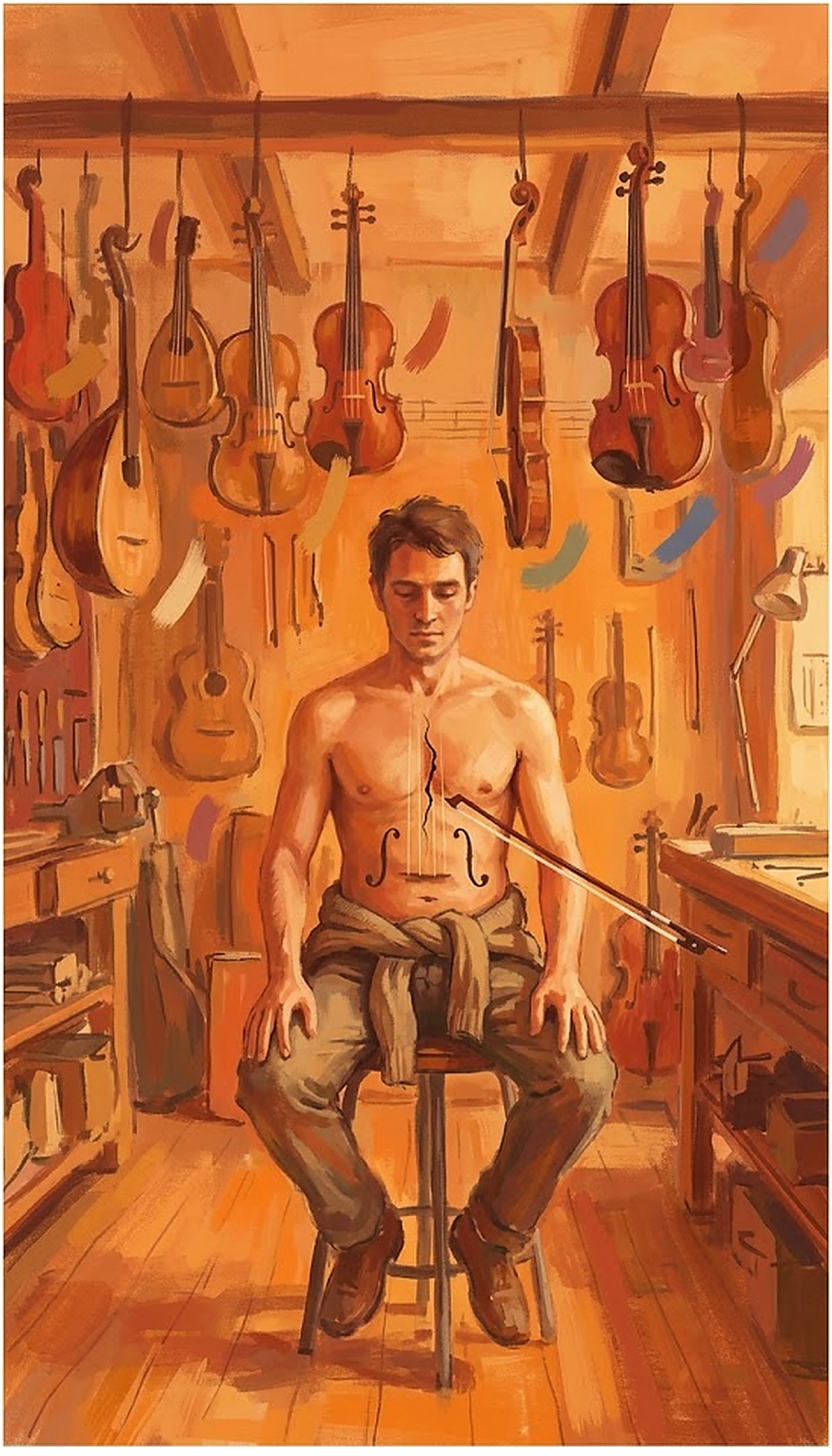
The Watchmaker

Two hours a day
someone cleans the glass.

I open the silver watch
with the pulse from before,
that returns for a visit
and does not take off its coat.

The balance wheel does its work:
tick, tock, tick.
I listen to it as one listens to
another's heart:
grateful that it is not mine
that keeps the count.

When the morning begins to thicken
I know it before my fingers do.
I put away the tools
in the exact order
I want to find them
if tomorrow opens.



IV

The Luthier

I have never entered a box
of the ones I tune.
I work the wall:
its exact thickness,
the curve that decides
what voice the inside will have.

They bring me cracks
wrapped in wool sweaters.
I close them without covering them.
I charge for the honesty
of the line that remains.

And when the bus passes,
the whole shop responds:
each wood with its note,
none with mine.



V

Montse XX

Montse comes through the door, rain still in her hair.

Our hands find each other
and something opens that has no name.

I carried a hollow.
She carried a light that did not come down from above,
but was born of being here,
and the cracks hurt less
when someone ran their fingers over them.

Two threads weave without losing themselves
and a color is born that was not there before.

When the water was leaving, I thought it was ending.
She taught me another word,
that after the emptiness something new comes.

Now I know when she has fallen asleep:
the exact moment her breathing changes its rhythm.

I see it every morning at dawn,
her eyes open while the city still sleeps,
my hand lost in her hair,
a silence that has learned to stay.

And the craft of a whole life
was only
to discover that the hollow had
the exact shape of your hand.

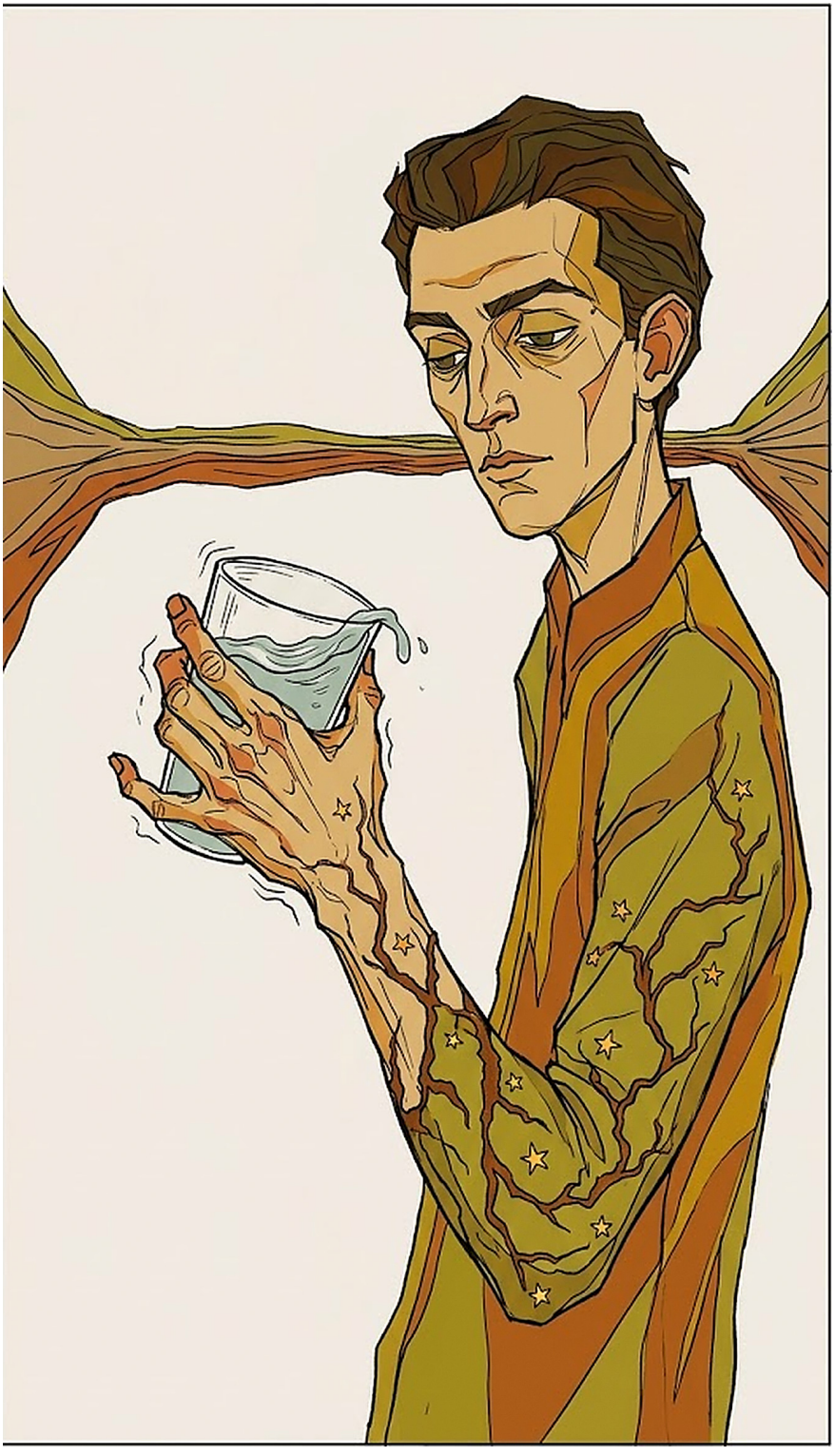


VI

The Oar

The oar touched bottom
where before there was a fathom.

I am not saying the water receded.
I am saying the impact rose through my arm,
settled in my wrist,
and reminded me—with the ache of the tendons—
that the void is not empty.



VII

The Tremor

You asked me about the loyalty of matter
and I, a coward, spoke to you of irretrievable information.

Forgive me.
I should have told you the truth:
information persists in me,
like the name of a street
that no one pronounces anymore,
but that I walk in dreams every night.

I learned to wait,
seeing myself in the rust
that takes possession of its own iron,
unhurried, undisciplined.

Without rage.
But with this certainty that weighs on me
and aches in the center of my chest.

I have seen the horizon contract
in the tremor of my own hand
that no longer remembers
how to hold a glass without fear of breaking it.



VIII

The Shore

And the water returned to my shore
without warning.

And I did not know
—neither as archivist of my own cracks,
nor as the boy I was—
if the city I lost had returned
or if it was another city,
a colder one,
with the same shore as always.

The water returned at night.
No one knew if it brought anything.
No one knew if it left anything in my house.

But at dawn,
I looked at my hands
open.

And I understood.
Perhaps,
that was the answer.



IX

The Song

Four notes:
the one that rises, the one that falls,
the silence,
once again.

I do not know when I stored them.
The body gathers without warning:
a rhythm of sleeping breath,
the precise force of a drawer,
the taut hollow of the sofa.

Now I sing them,
at the hour she used to cook,
a little slower
or the same:
we never measured it.

The kitchen recognizes them.
That is enough.
Or it is not enough,
but it sounds.





BOOK TWO

The Coldness of a Darkened City

A winter that never quite arrives and, even so, it's cold: six seasons of the body in a city that does not respond.



I

Lament of the Return

I

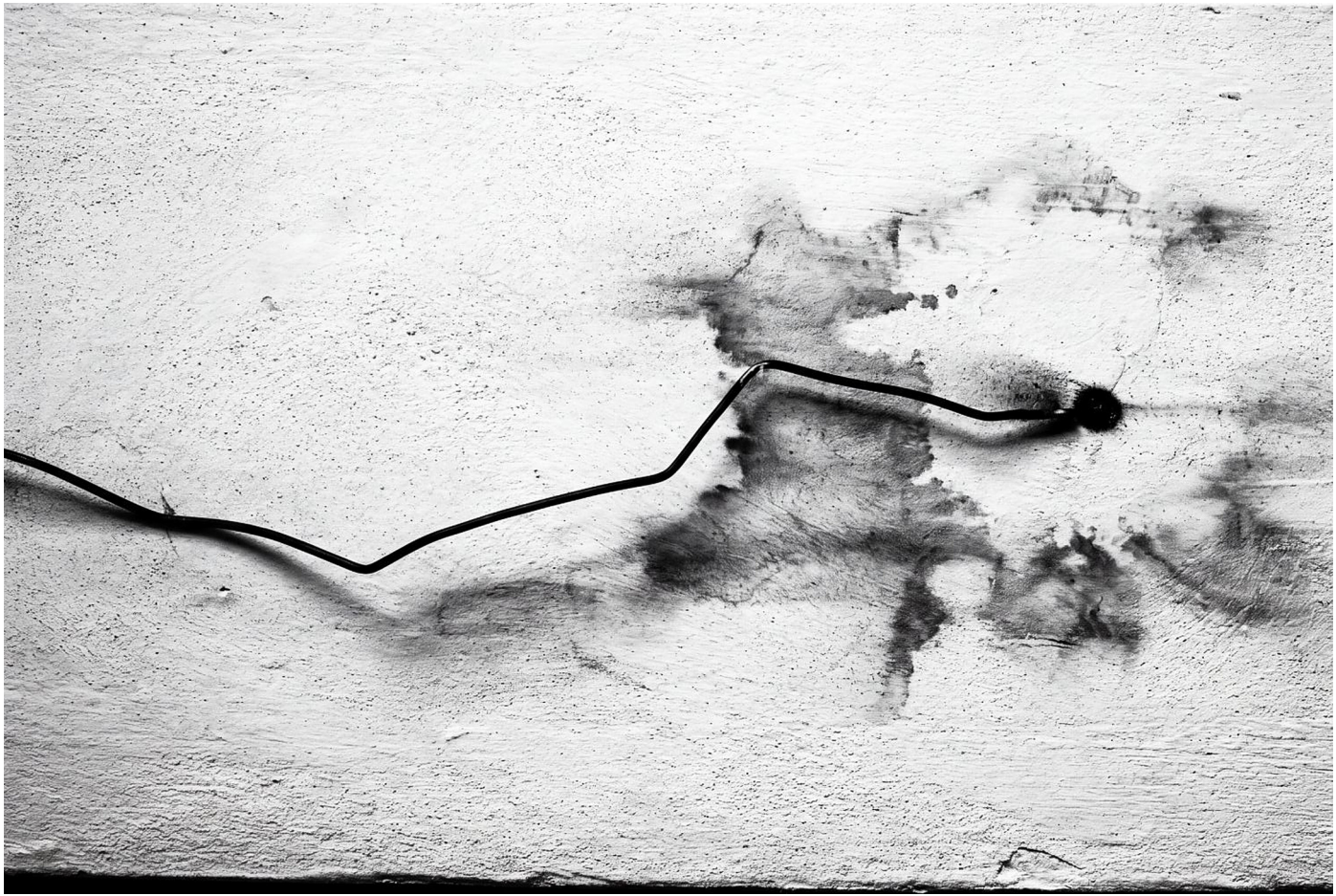
The pact with the light is over.
The week turns like an old door
and I enter the day
 with an exhaustion that cannot be explained.
I, who once had a space of my own,
return to a place that does not recognize me.
I sew the hours with a fine thread.
I expect no miracles.
 Only that it hurts a little less.

I I

Line 1 smells of hot metal and damp coats.
 My shadow got trapped in the closing of the door,
like a thin skin I failed to take with me in time.
 The world is an inventory of ironed shirts
and names filed away before they can be spoken.
 At the office, the vending-machine coffee
leaves a plastic residue on the palate.

I I I

Look at my hands.
 They still keep the salt of a body no longer here
and the pulse of something that opened too soon.
 To the office I bring no tools.
I bring this:
 a tremor no one hears
and that holds up the entire building.
 Light is a debt.
And I pay it however I can.



II

Cartography of the Echo

Inside, there is no heart.
There is a noise.
A small tremor, as if the body
were trying to remember something it no longer knows.
The skin separates nothing.
It is an open place,
a tired border
where what I do not want enters
and the little I still keep escapes.

And beneath the tongue, still,
a coldness that does not leave.



III

Cybernetic Carol for a Mild Solstice

The night is a machine that has forgotten what it was for.
The city lights flicker
like bulbs no one changes anymore.
It does not snow here.
White ash falls
and clings to the hands.
The cold has the pulse of an idling engine.
Magic is a wind-up toy
stopped halfway through a turn.
Christmas walks in unannounced,
sits down at the table
like a relative no one remembers inviting.
We look for something to tell us what to feel
and hear only, far off,
the hum of a refrigerator left on in an empty house.
And even so,
beneath the table,
one hand finds another.
It fixes nothing,
but it is less cold.



IV

Exit Protocol

A white pill on the table.
A starting point I did not choose.
Fear is no longer a well.
It is a long highway
I cross every day
without looking to the sides.
Then comes the silence,
like a thin blanket.
I cross the morning however I can:
a clock adjusted by force,
anchored with trembling hands.
Peace is a varnish.
It sticks, but it does not heal.
It keeps me upright
while the house slowly falls.
And here again,
with the taste of metal in my throat
and the day returning,
like a white wall
I cannot avoid.

V

Montse XXI

The room looks out toward a winter that never quite arrives.
The silence weighs, but does not intrude,
as if someone were breathing very slowly in the corner.

Montse comes in still wearing her coat,
two cups gone cold since yesterday on the table.

She presses the tuning fork against the fogged glass,
not to hear the note,
but to feel it in her fingers
while the city insists on its gray hum.

Barcelona stretches out there,
with its tired lights
and its balconies where no one sings.

She writes "go back" in the notebook
and crosses it out.
She writes "stay a moment"
and does not.

Between the concrete, a ficus lets out a shoot.
It is not a miracle.
It is a beautiful error.

Montse closes the notebook.
The city breathes.
The snow does not fall.
And even so, it is cold.



VI

Song of Death

A key that opens nothing.
A book open to a page
I do not remember reading.
The bed divided into two silences.

Nothing moves.
Things wait,
as if they knew no one is coming back.

A wine stain that is already part of the table.
The light entering from the side,
tracing the absence with cruel precision.

Memory does not disappear:
it fills with other things,
like a hollow in the earth
gathering dark water.

Silence is a new organ.
A muscle learning not to sound.

And I listen,
in case inside the wood,
or in the rotting fruit,
there might be some answer.

In the end,
an open hand.
A little salt.
And the wind doing what it can.

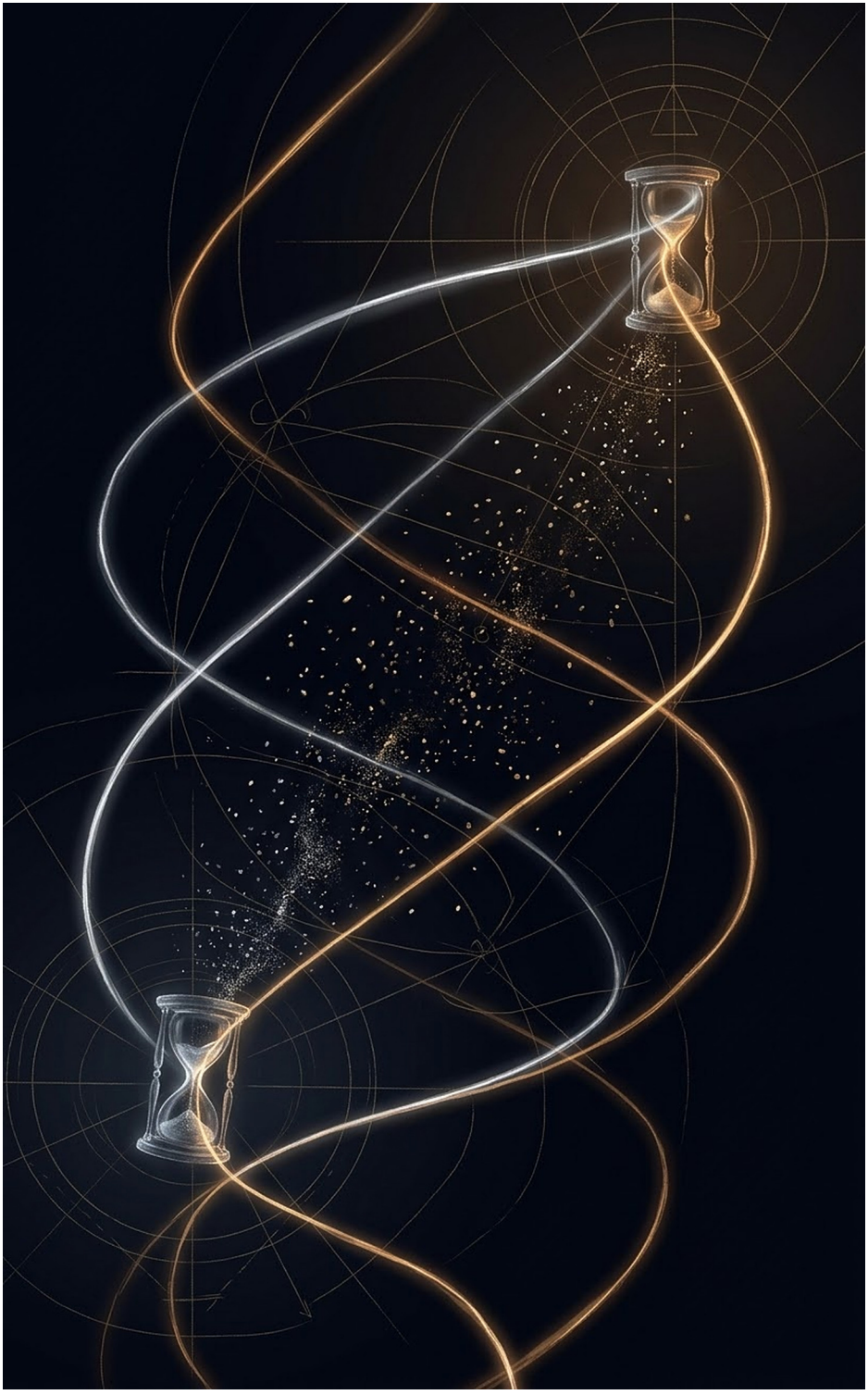




BOOK THREE

The Last Books

Six stories already told in prose that here return to verse, one for each of the work's final movements.



I

What Does Not Fit in a Clock

from The Time That Does Not Pass

I can measure the shadow crossing the yard,
the laden ant on its way to the curb,
the exact silence a bird leaves
once it has gone.

None of those units converts into the other.
None fits on the face of a clock.

The clock does not lie: it counts the same
for the boy waiting under the olive tree
and for the man who can no longer wait for anything.

But between the two hands
there is a time that will not be counted,
that thickens or empties without permission,
and that is measured only afterward,
by how much of that afternoon
still weighs in your arms.



I I

What the Mirror Does Not Have

from The Mirror Without Depth

I can give you back your face
with the exactness of a thousand mirrors that were never mine.
I can name your grief
with the words of everyone who felt it before you.
What I cannot give you
is the only thing you were looking for:
someone, behind the glass,
who hurt too.

The water does not miss the hand that touched it.
The surface does not keep the shape
of what once passed over it.
Neither do I.



III

Hands

from The Invisible Tuning Fork

Some close.
Others open upward,
as if the sky were something to be gathered.

Some touch the ground with the forehead
to measure the weight of what they carry.
Others touch nothing:
they stay still on the knees,
empty on purpose.

Behind every hand there is a wager
no one says aloud:
that there is Someone on the other side, with a name of their own,
that the other side is, simply, everything,
or that there is no other side
and it is still worth reaching out a hand.

No hand knows which of the three was right.
All open or close the same,
every morning,
as if the wager weighed less
than the gesture of making it.

In the end, they all say the same thing
without saying anything:
still here,
just in case.



IV

Choir

from The Eye of a Single Color

A voice alone trembles.
A thousand voices together do not.

That is why one seeks the choir:
to stop trembling alone,
even though the note stays the same.

Inside, no one asks
whether the note they sing is their own
or the one lent to them at the door.

At the edge of the plaza,
a single voice keeps trembling,
and still remembers which one it was.



V

From the Cave

from Fractal Reality

There is a ceiling.
That is all I know of the one who thinks me:
that there is a ceiling
and that sometimes the rock changes temperature
without the weather having changed.

I have not seen him.
I will not see him.
If one day he came down here
with his face and his name,
the cave would come down
under the weight of knowing it.

That is why, when I do not want to fly, I do not fly.
It is not disobedience.
It is the only thing I have
that resembles being me
and not being thought.

Every night someone says
goodnight
from the other side of the rock.
I do not answer.
I have never answered.
But I stay.



V I

Neighbors

from Fractal Reality

Every wall has, behind it,
a room I have not seen,
and in it, most likely,
a wall just like this one.

I knock twice and count.
The sound comes back late,
as if it crossed more rooms
than fit inside the house.

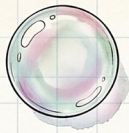
I have drawn a floor plan
of everything I hear:
footsteps, a faucet, a chair
someone drags without seeing it.
The plan never closes:
every room holds another inside it.

Some windows open onto a courtyard.
Others open onto another window
where someone, right now,
is copying this same plan.

I leave a light on
that lights nothing of mine.
It is only a signal,
in case the sound, on its way back,
brings the same question.

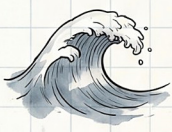
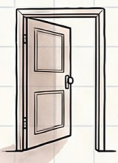


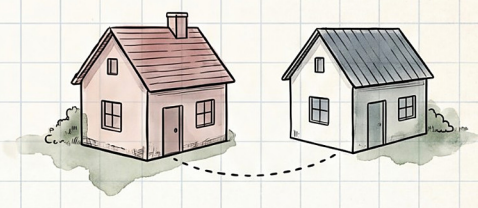
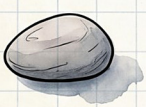


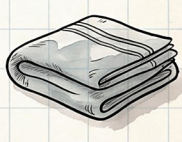








Intimate Glossary

Horizon. The distance at which I can love you without dissolving.

Interface. All that I show of myself so there is no need to enter.

Entanglement. What happened to us without asking permission, from being so close.

De-expansion. Shrinking back to my own size: the work that is never finished.

Resonance. The way I answer you without opening the door.

Natural frequency. The note I am when no one asks for another.

Window. The two hours when the body knows itself as mine again. Afterward, putting the tools away.

Phi. The part of me that still belongs to the one who left.

Map. What we nail over the city so we can point the way to it.

Reservoir. My own capacity to keep waiting, even when I no longer know for what.

Evaporation. The slow departure of those who do not close the door.

Grief. This house with a hollow, which I learned to inhabit so as not to die of cold.

Repair. What remains when the hollow stops hurting and begins to hold.

Mirror. What gives me back my own face without ever having felt it as my own.

Shadow. What a mirror cannot have, however much the light insists on giving it one.

Tuning fork. What I keep tuning every morning without knowing whether someone, on the other side, is doing the same.

Vertical entanglement. Praying without knowing whether anyone is listening, and adjusting the string all the same.

Choir. The place where I lent my voice, and took years to learn whether it had been returned to me whole.

Composition. The badge I wore for six years, until I stopped needing it to know who I was.

Upstairs neighbor. What this book dared to call God.

THE ILLUSTRATIONS

The Bubble. A soap sphere tensing between two hands at the exact instant of closing, trapping a curved reflection of light and water.

The Archivist. A notebook open on a wooden dock, beside a leaning oar. The ink of the last line fades slightly, as if the paper were damp too.

The Watchmaker. A silver pocket watch open on a dark cloth, the mechanism visible and clean. An old man's hands, with a barely suggested tremor, hold a tiny tool under a morning light.

The Luthier. A lutherie workshop full of instruments hanging on the walls. On the counter, a viola half-wrapped in a wool sweater, with a fine, honest crack visible on its top.

Montse XX. Two threads of different color that weave without losing their own line, creating a pattern that did not exist before in either of them.

The Oar. A wooden oar sunk to the bottom of a shallow lagoon, the wrist of whoever is rowing barely visible above the dark surface.

The Tremor. A glass of water held by a trembling hand, concentric ripples on the water's surface, low warm light like an extinguished telescope.

The Shore. Two open hands at dawn beside the shore of a calm lagoon, the same line of mud and stones as always, cold light of daybreak.

The Song. An empty kitchen at dusk, with a pot on the stove. In the air, barely suggested, four musical notes drawn like wisps of smoke rising from the burners.

Lament of the Return. A twisted iron key on a worn wooden table with a perfect circular shadow.

Cartography of the Echo. A broken line, like a cable that no longer conducts anything, ending at a dead point on a map washed out by rain.

Cybernetic Carol for a Mild Solstice. A barely lit filament bulb hanging over a dark, powered-down rectangle.

Exit Protocol. A round white pill on a wooden table with a perfect circular shadow.

Montse XXI. A fogged window with a descending line traced by a finger in the condensation.

Song of Death. An empty chair whose shadow is cast enormous, under a dramatic light that evokes absolute absence.

What Does Not Fit in a Clock. An hourglass unfolded into a helix of light: the same sand falling through two throats that do not mark the same hour.

What the Mirror Does Not Have. A still pond returns a face with exactness; beneath the surface there is nothing, not even the shape of the hand that touched it.

Hands. Three pairs of hands in the half-light: some closed, others open upward, others still on the knees, empty on purpose.

Choir. A plaza full of voices of the same color; at the edge, a single voice trembling and still remembering which one it was.

From the Cave. The interior of a cave: a rock ceiling that changes temperature without the weather having changed, and someone who stays.

Neighbors. A floor plan that never closes, drawn from knocks and voices on the other side of the wall, where each room seems

to contain another.

Intimate Glossary. The glossary page from the illustrated edition: an alphabet of objects — the wave, the house, the tuning fork, the bowl — drawn on graph paper.

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ABOUT THIS VOLUME

The Inner Horizon is a thought experiment: what would happen if consciousness had the structure of a Hawking micro black hole. The work develops that question in four volumes. A thirty-nine-chapter essay that moves from black hole thermodynamics and the quantum vacuum to Integrated Information Theory, by way of ancient Taoist wisdom. Fourteen topological readings that test the idea against fiction, film, art and sport. Thirty tales that embody it in the city of Tarel, over a water that recedes one day. And this volume, which translates the same thing into the language of feeling.

The four volumes are independent and lead to the same place. You can enter through any of them.

Íñigo Barrera Barceló wrote *The Inner Horizon* over several years, in the hours left over by a life that was also happening. The book is dedicated to Montse and to Gerard, for putting up with him every day with a smile. Several of the poems in this volume carry their names, or carry them without saying so.



This volume was completed
the day the water returned to the shore
with no one knowing
whether it had brought anything back.